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Barney Lutz: Baseball Will Miss Him

By AL MALLETTE

Baseball was Barney Lutz' life.

He began swinging bats around his home in Lucinda, Pa., as a youngster and became a professional baseball player in 1936 at Fayettesville, Ark. He was 19.

His 30-year pro career ended July 11.

Barney was stricken with a heart attack at the Geneva, N.Y., ball park and died minutes later at the Geneva Hospital.

Barney Lutz

He would have been 51 on Aug. 20.

Like Earl Weaver, Gerry Hannahoe, Paul Paynick, Gowell Claset, Packy Rogers and Stu Komer, among others, Barney was an Elmira Pioneer who liked Elmira so much that he settled here.

Lutz would travel the baseball path throughout the spring, summer and early fall, then come back to Elmira for the winter. He spent many a winter's "vacation" working beside old buddy Andy Cohen at H. Strauss Inc. men's store.

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Barney was tabbed as a "baseball nomad" because his stops were many.

Take his playing career.

It started in Fayettesville, Ark., and proceeded through Dayton, Ohio; Clinton, Ill.; Greenwood, Miss.; Pine Bluff, Ark.; Nashville, Tenn.; Anniston, Ala.; Elmira, Wichita Falls, Kan.; Wilmington, Del.; Toledo, Ohio and Toronto.

As a manager, first for the Phils, then the Browns-Orioles, Lutz spent summers in Carbondale and Bradford, Pa.; Thedford Mines, Canada; Wilson, N.C.; Thompson, Ga.; Paris and Amarillo, Tex.; Aberdeen, Wis. and Bluefield, Va.

Most of the communities are just dots on the map. But Barney Lutz made friends at every stop.

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BARNEY GAVE UP the bumpy bus ride circuit in 1959 when the Orioles name dhim a fulltime scout in the New York-Pennsylvania-Ontario area.

Barney has signed several players over the years, but none has reached the majors so far. His brightest prospect is Ed Barnowski, the no-hit pitcher of Elmira fame last season who has won his last six at Rochester this season.

Lutz always wished he could get one boy from the Elmira area who had the tools to go all the way.

He helped some get tryouts at the Orioles' training base at Thomasville, Ga., (the Orioles moved to Fernandina Beach, Fla., last spring), but none made it.

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AT A RECENT Dunn Field visit Barney mentioned the lack of good baseball in the area and how it was too bad because of the demand for good players today.

"People in this area just don't take the interest in building high school and post high school leagues for the boys," said Barney.

"Heck, boys can't play once or twice a week like they do in these local leagues and expect to make a career of baseball. And the boys can't play if the adult supervisors and coaches don't make the playing time available.

"I know of cases in area baseball where good high school players join summer teams and don't pick up a bat or throw a ball from one game to the next—and sometimes there is four-five days between games."

Barney often bemoaned the fact that the Elmira area didn't offer more baseball for the amateurs. And one of Barney's long-time buddies, scout Packy Rogers, backed him all the way.

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LUTZ ACTUALLY came to Elmira on a pass.

He has started as a member of the St. Louis Cardinal organization but was in it only a year when Commissioner Kenesaw Landis declared about 200 Cardinal farmhands free agents. Barney was one of them.

That was 1937.

By 1942, Barney had progressed to Class A Williamsport. But after that 1942 season, Williamsport figured it had enough of the war-time Eastern League and quit.

John Ogden also pulled out of the EL at the same time and turned his Elmira franchise back to an independent local group. The Elmira group was given title to several Williamsport players, including Lutz.

The 1943 switch to Elmira proved beneficial to Barney.

He was the big RBI man with 89 and topped the EL with 35 doubles as he led the 1943 Pioneers to the Governor's Cup championship.

At the end of the season Barney and teammates Sam Zoldak and Edgar Busch moved up to Connie Mack's Philadelphia Athletics.

Barney never got started as a major leaguer.

Mack sent Lutz and Zoldak as a rookie package to the St. Louis Browns in exchange for veteran catcher Frankie Hayes.

Before he could report to the Browns in 1944, Barney was drafted and sent to the Sampson Naval Training Station.

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HE WAS DISCHARGED 1946 in time for spring training. The Browns sent him to Toledo and later to Elmira, where he hit .292.

He started 1947 as a Pioneer but, after hitting .257 for 100 games, was shipped to Wichita Falls.

A .359 start at Wilmington in 1948 got him a shot at Toronto. He hit .307 for the Leafs in more than 100 gams.

The next year was Barney's first as a player—manager. This time he had moved to the Phillie organization.

His Carbondale club finished fifth, but Barney blasted a .321 average.

In 1950 he was at Bradford, Pa., in the Pony League.

Bradford finished fourth but Barney had his greatest year as a player. He hit .389 and drove home 131 runners—and he would have won the bat title except that Hornell's Oscar Sierra hit .422. That was his last full season as a regular player.

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BARNEY WAS A LEAN, wiry 5-10, 170-pounder during his playing days. He was the same as a scout.

He was a picture swinger who stroked for the doubles and singles—and the records show he was always among the leaders in doubles in the various leagues in which he played. Barney could play several positions, but the outfield was his home.

Barney's son Pat, a catcher-infielder, resembled his dad with the bat. While at Elmira Notre Dame, Pat hit safely in an Elmira scholastic record 29 games over three seasons.

But dad wanted his son to get an education, so Pat went to Syracuse and got a degree. He took a shot at baseball, but as his dad said, "If he makes it in baseball, good. If he doesn't he's got something else."

Lutz was a pusher for the college-education bonus contract.

"It's the best contract baseball ever offered for a high school prospect," said Lutz. "The boy's education is paid for regardless of size of bonus. Of course, this is aimed at the small smaller bonus boys."

Barney Lutz was a baseball man's baseball man.

I, for one, am going to miss him.

The Dunn Field clientele is going to miss him.

Baseball is going to miss him.

Big Flats Lists Cindy Stars

Members of the Big Flats Cinderella All-Star team have been selected, and all girls chosen are urged to be at the Cinderella diamond on Monday, July 18 at 3:50 p.m. to have pictures taken.

The first All-Star practice will be Wednesday, July 20 from 2-4 p.m.

All-Star team members are: Cassandara Post, Cheryl Smith, Mary Hoagland and Regina Brenner of Gould's Golf; Leslie Holmes and Enice Burke of Morrison's Resturant; Jackie Faille, Karen Berlin, Pamela Bates and Kathleen Smith of Western Auto; Karen Hayberg, Jean Frost and Kathy Slocum of Wenzel's Paving; Ellen Richards of the Jaycees and Deborah Andrews of Frenches' Trucking.

Co-managers are Elizabeth Farr of Morrison's Restaurant and Emma Gardner of the Jaycees.

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Screen House	12 x 12	Screen House	84.30	48.88
Dining Canopy #505	12 x 12	Dining Canopy	34.95	19.88
Celebrity #622	10 x 12	Outside Frame Cottage Floor	179.90	109.88
Coleman Oasis 8468-350	13 x 10	Outside Frame Cottage Floor	209.95	129.88
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